Diwali Trip to Punjab & Himachal Pradesh

8 – 17 November 2026

Ahmedabad → Amritsar → Dalhousie → Dharamshala → Bir → Mandi → Lahaul → Jispa → Chandigarh

Plan as of: 25 October 2026

Changes from the earlier plan

- Skip Chamera Lake and Kangra Fort.
- Day 4: Mata Baglamukhi, HPCA Stadium and Kunal Pathri on the way to Dharamshala.
- Day 6: Norbulingka, Tashi Jong, Palpung Sherabling and Bir (no Baijnath), then night in Mandi — no night driving.
- Day 7: Mandi → Atal Tunnel → Sissu, then the Gondla homestay — first night in Lahaul.
- Day 8: a full day at Jispa and Darcha, warm lunch in Keylong (Baralacha La only if the road is open).

WHERE WE SLEEP

Sun, 8 Nov	On the train	On the train
Mon, 9 Nov	Amritsar	Booking pending
Tue, 10 Nov	Dalhousie Hotel Himdhara Dalhousie	Confirmed
Wed, 11 Nov	Dharamshala / McLeod Ganj Hotel Pine View	Confirmed
Thu, 12 Nov	Dharamshala / McLeod Ganj Hotel Pine View	Confirmed
Fri, 13 Nov	Mandi	Booking pending
Sat, 14 Nov	Gondla / Lahaul Valley View Homestay Fuktal, Lahaul	Confirmed
Sun, 15 Nov	Gondla / Lahaul Valley View Homestay Fuktal, Lahaul	Confirmed
Mon, 16 Nov	Mandi	Booking pending
Tue, 17 Nov	On the train (arrive GNC Wed 18 Nov, 03:05 PM)	On the train

TRAINS

19107 Janmabhoomi Express	Gandhinagar Capital (GNC) Sun 8 Nov · 10:05 AM	Jalandhar City Mon 9 Nov · 10:00 AM	3A · B1 37, 38, 40
19412 DLPC GNC Express	Chandigarh (CDG) Tue 17 Nov · 05:55 PM	Gandhinagar Capital (GNC) Wed 18 Nov · 03:05 PM	3A · B2 27, 29, 30

Booking numbers are partly hidden; check your email or SMS for the full numbers.

Day 1

Sunday, 8 November

The Departure

Ahmedabad → on the train

● **Relaxed** · Train day — rest on board

Wake up: As per your comfort

09:00 AM	Board Janmabhoomi Express from Ahmedabad (boarding station: Gandhinagar Capital (GNC) at 10:05 AM).

19107 · Janmabhoomi Express — Confirmed

Departs	Gandhinagar Capital (GNC) — Sun 8 Nov · 10:05 AM
Arrives	Jalandhar City — Mon 9 Nov · 10:00 AM
Class · Coach · Berths	3A · B1 · 37, 38, 40
PNR	••••••0791

Night stay: On the train

Day 2

Monday, 9 November

The Golden Hour

Jalandhar → Amritsar

● **Moderate** · Arrive after the night train; Wagah and Golden Temple; early night

Wake up: 07:30 AM (on the train, to get ready for arrival)

10:00 AM	Arrive at Jalandhar City Railway Station. Hire your Tempo Traveller.
10:30 AM – 12:30 PM	Drive from Jalandhar to Amritsar.
12:30 PM	Hotel check-in near the Golden Temple and lunch.
02:00 PM	Depart for the Wagah Border.
04:15 – 05:00 PM	Attari-Wagah Border Ceremony. **Tip:** Winter timings usually start at 4:15 PM, but arrive early to get seats.
07:30 PM	Sri Harmandir Sahib (Golden Temple) at night.
08:30 PM	Early dinner outside.
10:00 PM	Back at the hotel and asleep by 10 — tomorrow starts early. **Tip:** Pack the bags tonight so the morning is quick.

Hotel near the Golden Temple — Booking pending

Night stay: Amritsar

Day 3

Tuesday, 10 November

Ascent to Dalhousie & The Peak

Amritsar → Dalhousie

● **Busy** · Early start, ~5.5 h drive; Dainkund trek is optional

Wake up: 06:00 AM (bags packed the night before)

07:00 AM	Depart Amritsar.
12:30 PM	Arrive in Dalhousie, check into your hotel, and grab a quick lunch. **Tip:** Hotel check-in is from 2 PM — leave the luggage at reception and check in after the trek.
01:30 PM	Drive to the Dainkund Peak base.
02:00 – 05:00 PM	Dainkund Peak trek (2 km) — optional. **Tip:** Start by 2 PM to be off the trail before the 5:30 PM sunset. Anyone tired can skip it: rest at the hotel or wait at the base café and join the Mall Road walk later.
06:00 PM	Evening stroll at the Town Center, Mall Road, and colonial viewpoints.

Hotel Himdhara Dalhousie

Confirmed

Address	Church Baloon Road, near Gandhi Chowk, Dalhousie – 176304
Check-in	Tue 10 Nov, after 02:00 PM
Check-out	Wed 11 Nov, before 12:00 PM
Booked via	MakeMyTrip · Booking ID NH••••••••0644

Night stay: Dalhousie

Day 4

Wednesday, 11 November

Baglamukhi & Dharamshala

Dalhousie → Bankhandi → Dharamshala

● **Busy** · ~6 h on the road with three short stops

Wake up: 06:30 AM

08:00 AM	Check out and leave Dalhousie (no Chamera Lake).
08:00 AM – 12:45 PM	Drive via Nurpur and Ranital to Bankhandi (about 4.5 hours).
12:45 – 01:45 PM	Darshan at Mata Baglamukhi Temple, Bankhandi, then lunch. **Tip:** Check afternoon darshan timings — many temples close briefly around midday.
02:00 – 03:30 PM	Drive to Dharamshala (about 1.5 hours).
03:30 PM	HPCA Stadium — photo stop with the Dhauladhar behind.
04:00 PM	Kunal Pathri Temple in the tea gardens.
05:00 PM	Check in at Hotel Pine View. **Tip:** McLeod Ganj lanes are narrow and steep — ask the hotel beforehand whether the Tempo Traveller can reach it and where it can park.
06:00 PM	Evening on McLeod Ganj Mall Road.

Hotel Pine View

Confirmed

2 nights (Nov 11 – 13) · Night 1

Address	VPO Sudher, Dharamshala – 176215
Check-in	Wed 11 Nov, after 12:00 PM
Check-out	Fri 13 Nov, before 12:00 PM
Booked via	MakeMyTrip · Booking ID NH••••••••9134

Night stay: Dharamshala / McLeod Ganj

Day 5

Thursday, 12 November

Tibetan Heritage & Waterfalls

McLeod Ganj

● **Moderate** · Walking day, no long drive; easy afternoon by taxi

Wake up: 06:00 AM

07:00 AM	Leave the hotel to enjoy the crisp mountain air. **Tip:** McLeod Ganj lanes are too narrow for the Tempo Traveller — walk or use local taxis around McLeod, Bhagsu and Naddi today.
07:30 AM	Breakfast at a local bakery near the Main Square.
08:45 AM	Dalai Lama Temple & Museum (catch the morning chants).
11:00 AM	Bhagsunag Temple and the hike to Bhagsu Waterfall.
01:15 PM	Lunch at a hillside cafe with a view.
02:15 – 03:00 PM	Rest at the hotel after lunch.
03:15 PM	St. John in the Wilderness Church — short taxi ride, no walking uphill.
04:30 PM	Naddi View Point — by taxi. **Tip:** Arrive before the 5:30 PM sunset.
06:30 PM	Free time in Main Square for shopping and exploring.
07:30 PM	Dinner (authentic Tibetan food).

Hotel Pine View — Confirmed

Night 2 of 2

Night stay: Dharamshala / McLeod Ganj

Day 6

Friday, 13 November

Norbulingka, Sherabling & Bir

Dharamshala → Palampur → Tashi Jong → Sherabling → Bir → Mandi

● **Busy** · ~5.5 h on the road with four stops; reach Mandi around sunset

Wake up: 06:30 AM

07:45 AM	Early breakfast, check out of Hotel Pine View.
09:00 – 10:15 AM	Norbulingka Institute, Sidhpur — gardens, workshops, temple.
10:15 – 11:15 AM	Drive via Palampur, short stop at the tea gardens.
11:15 – 11:45 AM	Tashi Jong Khampagar Monastery, Taragarh (on the main road).
12:00 – 12:45 PM	Palpung Sherabling Monastery, Bhattu — on the lane between Baijnath and Bir. **Tip:** Main hall reportedly open 8:30 AM – 4:30 PM. No photos inside the prayer halls; dress modestly.
01:00 – 02:00 PM	Lunch in Bir.
02:00 – 03:00 PM	Bir Tibetan Colony, Chokling Monastery and the paragliding landing site.
03:00 – 05:45 PM	Drive via Joginder Nagar to Mandi (about 85 km, 2.5–3 hours). **Tip:** Leave Bir by 3 PM — only the last 20–30 minutes are after sunset.
06:00 PM	Check in at the Mandi hotel; easy evening.

Hotel in Mandi, by the Beas River — Booking pending

Book the same hotel for 13 and 16 Nov · Night 1

Night stay: Mandi

Day 7

Saturday, 14 November

Through the Tunnel to Lahaul

Mandi → Kullu → Atal Tunnel → Sissu → Gondla

● **Busy** · ~5.5 h drive up to Lahaul; early start, rest at the homestay

Wake up: 06:00 AM

07:00 AM – 12:15 PM	Drive from Mandi via Kullu and the Atal Tunnel to Sissu (about 160 km). **Tip:** Leave by 7 AM sharp. Check the Atal Tunnel / Lahaul road status the evening before — heavy snow can close it at short notice.
12:30 – 01:30 PM	Lunch around Sissu / Koksar.
01:30 – 02:15 PM	Sissu: waterfall viewpoint and the Chandra river banks. **Tip:** If snow is forecast, skip this stop and go straight to Gondla.
02:15 – 02:45 PM	Short drive on to Gondla (about 15 km).
02:45 PM	Check in at the homestay and rest — let your body get used to the altitude. **Tip:** Gondla is before Keylong, so there's no need to drive on to Keylong today — you pass it tomorrow.

Valley View Homestay Fuktal, Lahaul

Confirmed

Night 1 of 2 · first of two bookings — ask the host to keep the same rooms

Address	Village Fuktal, Gondla, Lahaul – 175140
Check-in	Sat 14 Nov, 12:00 – 02:00 PM
Check-out	Sun 15 Nov, before 10:00 AM
Booked via	Goibibo · Booking ID GH••••••••1666

Night stay: Gondla / Lahaul

Day **8**

Sunday, 15 November

A Full Day at Jispa

Gondla → Jispa → Darcha → Keylong → Gondla

● **Moderate** · Short drives, cold and high; back by 4 PM

Wake up: 07:00 AM

08:30 AM	Leave the homestay after breakfast; drive past Keylong towards Jispa. **Tip:** Fill fuel at the Tandi petrol pump on the way — the last fuel station for a long way.
09:30 AM	Gemur village and monastery, just before Jispa.
10:00 AM – 12:00 PM	Jispa: walk along the Bhaga river, the village and its small monastery; photos of the snow peaks.
12:00 – 12:30 PM	Darcha (7 km): river confluence, Darcha bridge and the police check post. **Tip:** Ask the police about the road ahead — usually closed by mid-November. If it is open and you go towards Zingzingbar / Deepak Tal / Baralacha La, skip the Keylong lunch, eat a packed lunch in the vehicle and turn back by 1 PM.
12:30 – 01:30 PM	Drive back down to Keylong (about 30 km).
01:30 – 02:30 PM	Warm indoor lunch in Keylong market. **Tip:** Around 0–4°C outside at this altitude in mid-November — too cold for a riverside picnic.
02:30 – 03:15 PM	Optional: Kardang Monastery, across the river from Keylong.
03:15 – 04:00 PM	Drive back to Gondla (about 25 km).
04:00 PM	Back at the homestay before the 5:15 PM sunset; stargazing at night. **Tip:** Icy roads after dark are the main risk — don't stay out late.

Valley View Homestay Fuktal, Lahaul

Confirmed

Night 2 of 2 · second booking, same rooms

Address	Village Fuktal, Gondla, Lahaul – 175140
Check-in	Sun 15 Nov, 12:00 – 02:00 PM
Check-out	Mon 16 Nov, before 10:00 AM
Booked via	Goibibo · Booking ID GH••••••••0370

Night stay: Gondla / Lahaul

Day 9

Monday, 16 November

The Lahaul Morning & Descent to Mandi

Gondla → Atal Tunnel → Mandi

● **Busy** · ~6 h drive down to Mandi; free evening

Wake up: 06:30 AM

07:30 – 09:00 AM	A crisp, snowy morning around the Gondla homestay; check out.
09:00 AM – 03:00 PM	Drive from Gondla back through the Atal Tunnel, bypassing Manali, down the river valley to Mandi (about 190 km, ~6 hours). **Tip:** Check the morning road advisory before leaving; leave early to allow for mountain traffic.
03:00 PM	Late lunch on arrival in Mandi (or stop along the route).
04:00 PM	Check into your hotel and relax by the Beas River.

Hotel in Mandi, by the Beas River — Booking pending

Same hotel as 13 Nov · Night 2

Night stay: Mandi

Day 10

Tuesday, 17 November

The Journey Home

Mandi → Chandigarh → home

● **Moderate** · ~5 h drive, about 5 h buffer before the train

Wake up: 06:30 AM

07:30 AM – 12:30 PM	Drive from Mandi to Chandigarh (approx. 5 hours). **Tip:** Leave early to account for mountain traffic.
12:30 – 03:00 PM	Lunch in Chandigarh. If time permits, a quick walk around Sukhna Lake.
04:00 PM	Arrive at Chandigarh Railway Station.
05:55 PM	Board the train to Gandhinagar from Chandigarh (CDG).

19412 · DLPC GNC Express — Confirmed

Departs	Chandigarh (CDG) — Tue 17 Nov · 05:55 PM
Arrives	Gandhinagar Capital (GNC) — Wed 18 Nov · 03:05 PM
Class · Coach · Berths	3A · B2 · 27, 29, 30
PNR	••••••7012

Night stay: On the train (arrive GNC Wed 18 Nov, 03:05 PM)

Still to do

- [ ] **Pay Hotel Himdhara, Dalhousie — ₹7,936**
  By Sat 7 Nov, 11:59 PM · MakeMyTrip
  Nothing paid yet — the booking is auto-cancelled if unpaid by then.
- [ ] **Pay Hotel Pine View, Dharamshala — ₹16,289**
  By Mon 9 Nov, 11:59 PM · MakeMyTrip
  Nothing paid yet. The deadline falls during the trip — pay before leaving on 8 Nov.
- [ ] **Pay Valley View Homestay, night of 14 Nov — ₹8,068**
  By Tue 10 Nov, 11:59 PM · Goibibo
  New booking (made 26 Oct). Nothing paid yet — pay before leaving on 8 Nov. Free cancellation until 11 Nov, 11:59 AM.
- [ ] **Pay Valley View Homestay, night of 15 Nov — ₹8,088**
  By Wed 11 Nov, 11:59 PM · Goibibo
  Nothing paid yet. The deadline falls during the trip — pay before leaving on 8 Nov.
- [ ] **Book a hotel in Amritsar near the Golden Temple**
  Night of Mon 9 Nov
- [ ] **Book a hotel in Mandi by the Beas river — the same hotel for both nights**
  Nights of Fri 13 and Mon 16 Nov
- [ ] **Message the homestay host: the two bookings are one stay (14–16 Nov) — keep the same 3 rooms; arriving ~3 PM on 14 Nov**
  Check-in window is 12–2 PM, so tell them in advance
- [ ] **Order meals with the homestay: vegetarian, no egg — dinner both nights, breakfasts, and a packed backup lunch for the Jispa day**
  Meals are extra — about ₹170 per person per meal, per the listing
- [ ] **Ask Hotel Pine View whether the Tempo Traveller can reach the hotel and where it can park**
  Before 11 Nov
- [ ] **Ask the Tempo Traveller operator to carry snow chains for Lahaul**
  Before the trip
- [ ] **Check both train timings on NTES**
  A few days before 8 Nov
- [ ] **Check the Atal Tunnel / Lahaul road status**
  Evening of Fri 13 Nov, in Mandi

Done

- [x] Tempo Traveller for the road trip
  Jalandhar 9 Nov → Chandigarh 17 Nov
- [x] Trains: 19107 Janmabhoomi Express and 19412 DLPC GNC Express
  8 Nov and 17 Nov
- [x] Hotel Himdhara, Dalhousie — booked
  Night of 10 Nov · payment still due, see above
- [x] Hotel Pine View, Dharamshala — booked
  Nights of 11–12 Nov · payment still due, see above
- [x] Valley View Homestay, Gondla — booked for both nights

14 Nov and 15 Nov (two Goibibo bookings) · payment still due, see above